

Better than Sufi Sex: Ibn Turka on the Superiority of Lettrism to Sufism as Model of Occult Islamic Humanism

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When thought marries memory, it births wonders.

— al-Jāhiz¹

Early modern Christian intellectual culture, as is well known, was characterized by a powerful perennialist turn, whereby the wisdom of the ancients was textually revived, or simply invented out of whole cloth. In the case of West Europe, we call this turn “the Renaissance.” But a similar turn was equally definitive of contemporary Islamic and especially Persianate intellection, and began in Iran many decades before it did in Italy. There its primary vehicle was the Platonic Orientalism of Suhrawardī (d. 1191), the applications of whose Illuminationist philosophy were very much occult.² In contrast to the *declinist* ethos of many Renaissance humanists, moreover, Persianate perennialism, equally humanist, was often paradoxically *progressivist*: the revival of ancient wisdom must lead to its supersession, to the invention of (occult) sciences never before known, to the modern transformation of man into microcosm.³

Among the architects of this progressivist, perennialist, humanist and occultist

¹ *Idhā nakaha l-fikru l-hifza wallada l-‘ajā’iba*: ‘Amr b. Baḥr al-Jāhiz (d. 869), quoted in Jalāl al-Dīn al-Suyūfī (d. 1505), *Inbā’ al-adhkiyā’ bi-ḥayāt al-anbiyā’*, ed. Sa’īd Muḥammad al-Laḥḥām (Beirut: ‘Ālam al-Kutub, 1417/1997), 25. My thanks to Hussein Abdulsater for this reference.

² John Walbridge, *The Leaven of the Ancients: Suhrawardī and the Heritage of the Greeks* (Albany: State University of New York Press, 2000); Łukasz Piątek, “Between Philosophy, Mysticism and Magic: A Critical Edition of Occult Writings of and Attributed to Shihāb al-Dīn al-Suhrawardī (1156-1191)” (Ph.D. diss., University of Warsaw, 2018); Reza Pourjavady and Sabine Schmidtke, “An Eastern Renaissance? Greek Philosophy under the Safavids (16th-18th Centuries AD),” *Intellectual History of the Islamicate World* 3 (2015): 248-90; Ahab Bdaiwi, “Late Antique Intellectualism in Medieval Islam: The Shiraz Circle and the Revival of Ancient and Islamic Knowledge,” in *The Renaissance of Shi’i Islam in the Fifteenth to Seventeenth Centuries*, ed. Janis Esots (London: Bloomsbury, forthcoming 2022). For a parallel example see Michael-Sebastian Noble, *Philosophising the Occult: Avicennan Psychology and ‘The Hidden Secret’ of Fakhr al-Dīn al-Rāzī* (Berlin: de Gruyter, 2021).

³ An argument for the relative stodginess of Renaissance humanism is made in Lynn Thorndike, “Renaissance or Prenaissance?,” *Journal of the History of Ideas* 4, no. 1 (1943): 65-74.

turn is Ibn Turka (1369-1432), Shafi'i judge of Isfahan and Yazd and most prominent occult philosopher of Timurid Iran. He was responsible for systematizing *lettrism* (*'ilm al-ḥurūf*) – Hebrew kabbalah's coeval Arabic twin, and likewise of medieval western Mediterranean vintage – as both proof of the occult-scientific superiority of the Moderns to the Ancients and apotheosis of the Solomonic-Pythagorean legacy. The lettrist wave Ibn Turka helped launch would continue to swell for centuries after his death, permeating many aspects of Persianate elite and popular culture alike, from empire and science to book painting and riddles.⁴

As with all paradigm shifts, however, his project was vehemently challenged in his own lifetime and immediately after by more conservative or mercenary scholars, and he was thrice subjected to inquisition at the Timurid imperial capital in Herat. In particular, his insistence on the philosophical-scientific superiority of lettrism to *sufism* (*'ilm al-taṣawwuf*), and his refusal to identify or live as a sufi, rankled in certain quarters – as did his frequent dismissal of contemporary schoolmen and sufis alike as stodgy reactionaries, ignorant propagandists and conniving mafiosos. Some opponents, jealous of his influence, denounced him, ironically, as a “radical sufi,” or even a “failed sufi.”⁵

But Ibn Turka was not slow to retort, and in 1425, at the height of his career, dedicated a Persian treatise to the same theme: *The Conclusion; or, Sufism versus Lettrism* (*Anjām, yā Taṣawvuf va ḥurūf*). This work is of particular salience for early modernist Western intellectual and cultural historians, most of whom have to date ignored the astonishing parallelism between Latinate and Persianate developments; these suggest that the category of Renaissance must be seen as a much larger Afro-Eurasian process defining the fourteenth to seventeenth centuries, and featuring precisely this Solomonic-Pythagorean perennialism as a core theme throughout the Greater West.⁶ It is likewise instructive for Islamicists, who still tend to reflexively lump sufism and occultism together under the rubric of “esotericism” or, worse, “mysticism” – the better to disappear Islamic occult science from the history of science and the history of empire altogether.⁷ As Ibn Turka contends

⁴ On his biography and legacy see e.g., Matthew Melvin-Koushki, “The New Brethren of Purity: Ibn Turka and the Renaissance of Neopythagoreanism in the Early Modern Persian Cosmopolis,” forthcoming; idem, “The Quest for a Universal Science: The Occult Philosophy of Sā'in al-Dīn Turka Iṣfahānī (1369-1432) and Intellectual Millenarianism in Early Timurid Iran” (Ph.D. diss., Yale University, 2012).

⁵ Ibid., 58-68, 418-19.

⁶ For intellectual- and cultural-historiographical purposes, I define the West as follows (“*Tahqīq* vs. *Taqīd* in the Renaissances of Western Early Modernity,” *Philological Encounters* 3, no. 1 [2018]: 193-249): the half of Afro-Eurasia west of South India, incorporating the Arabic, Persian and Latin cosmopolises, that vast realm where the Hellenic-Abrahamic synthesis reigned supreme, and philosophy was pursued in simultaneously mathematical-linguistic terms. To the extent that parts of Southeast Asia were fully incorporated into Islam during this period, moreover, by this definition they are to be considered Western, just as Australia is today.

⁷ Nineteenth-century European developments aside, I use “occultism” generically to refer to a scholarly investment in one or more of the occult sciences, such as astrology, alchemy, lettrism, geomancy, physiognomy or oneiromancy, usually formally designated as such in Arabo-Persian classifications of the sciences, biographical dictionaries, theological and legal tracts, etc. See Mat-

to the contrary, however, his simultaneously natural, mathematical *and* scriptural Solomonic-Pythagorean science must never be confused with sufism. For the first is the royal road to enlightenment, the ultimate form of *intellectual sex*; the second is a worthy but emphatically lesser and preparatory path of self-improvement for *intellectual prepubescents*. (Here the insult “He can’t get it up” takes on a whole new valence!)

Given its typological usefulness for Islamicists and Europeanists alike, and especially historians of Western esotericism, in what follows I will briefly situate Ibn Turka’s treatise within his larger project and its sociopolitical context, drawing instructive parallels to slightly later but cognate developments in Latin Christendom, then identify the Islamic intellectual-historical stakes of his strict distinction between lettrism and sufism. Finally, I provide a full translation as basis for the comparative study of early modern Western humanisms.

Ibn Turka and the Timurid Renaissance of Occult Islamic Humanism

Much ink has been spilled by Islamicists and non-Islamicists alike on the theme of “Islamic humanism.” Predictably, however, not a little of that ink has been at pains to argue that a premodern or modern Muslim thinker can only be a humanist to the extent he (rarely she) elevates reason over revelation, science over religion, shaking off the shackles of antirational Islam – a Semitic creed – by cleaving to Hellenic rationalist precedent. (That European humanists were often vociferously committed to a sister Semitic creed rarely enters into the discussion.) This argument then usually devolves into a polemic against the contemporary illiberal anti-humanism of Islam and/or an apology urging a return to Islam’s liberal, humanistic golden age. Equally predictably, that golden age is almost exclusively identified with Islam’s “classical” period, when Arab religion was suffused with Greek reason in the wake of the great translation movement under Abbasid imperial aegis.⁸ The “Renaissance of Islam”⁹ – if we are permitted to speak of one – was hence a strictly medieval affair, and a mere prefigurement of The Renaissance of Latin Christendom, prelude in turn to The Scientific Revolution. Confirming Islam’s eternal medievalness, Ibn Khaldūn (d. 1406) has been singled out by the modern,

threw Melvin-Koushki, “Is (Islamic) Occult Science Science?,” *Theology and Science* 18, no. 2 (2020): 303-24.

⁸ Emblematic here is Lenn E. Goodman’s *Islamic Humanism* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2003), which recycles the old Orientalist chestnut of Islam’s permanent cultural decline after the eleventh century; see Nahyan Fancy’s review of the same in *Journal of Near Eastern Studies* 66, no. 2 (2007): 151-53. Similarly, pundits periodically call for an Islamic Reformation – oblivious of the very long and very bloody history of that process within Latin Christendom, which culminated in World War I. For an incisive and critical review of the specialist literature see Marco Schöller, “Zum Begriff des ‘islamischen Humanismus,’” *Zeitschrift der Deutschen Morgenländischen Gesellschaft* 151 (2001): 275-320.

⁹ Joel Kraemer makes a strong case for this in his *Humanism in the Renaissance of Islam: The Cultural Revival during the Buyid Age*, 2nd rev. ed. (Leiden: Brill, 1992).

liberal historian as a latter-day but solitary and perversely ignored champion of this humanistic ideal after the “classical” period, whose genius can only be recognized by the Enlightened European mind.¹⁰

Such a formulation is patently colonialist-Orientalist, and as such has been retired on various fronts, including the history of Islamic art, literature, philosophy and law. It is also both ahistorical and teleological, equating humanism with the antireligious tenor of the Enlightenment. Yet it still structures a surprisingly large share of the current historiography of Islam more generally, defining the parameters of what an Islamic humanism should look like. The outsized literature on Ibn Khaldūn is a case in point: that fulminations against both occultism and sufism make up a significant percentage of his celebrated project only confirms his status as a proto-Enlightenment figure – no matter that the Tunisian historian’s attacks are rather couched in the rhetoric of puritanical and conservative piety, and condemn philosophy as irreligion.¹¹

But here there is a telling slippage: in the West European context, occultism and humanism were far from opposed. To the contrary, so frequently were the Christian humanist heroes of the Renaissance – like their “Scientific Revolution” heirs – ardent occultists that an investment in the (often Arabic) occult sciences would seem to be a hallmark of early modern humanism, not its antithesis.¹² The huge body of scholarship on such feted figures as Giovanni Pico della Mirandola (d. 1494), Marsilio Ficino (d. 1499), Heinrich Cornelius Agrippa (d. 1535), Giordano Bruno (d. 1600) and John Dee (d. 1609), to take only the most obvious examples, amply testifies to this point. By comparison, Ibn Khaldūn comes off not as a humanist, but as a failed Inquisitor, his anti-occultist screeds ignored for centuries. This Europeanist-Islamicist double standard is only beginning to be flagged by specialists.

So why have equally occultist and humanist Muslim thinkers been all but erased from our narrative of early modern occultist humanism? If the evidence exists, as it does in spades, why not imagine the possibility of a parallel early modern Islamic humanism?

To begin to evaluate such a comparative claim, a usable definition of *humanism* is necessary. The vast literature on this slippery ethos is wildly contradictory, and

¹⁰ Stephen F. Dale’s *The Orange Trees of Marrakesh: Ibn Khaldun and the Science of Man* (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 2015), which celebrates him as a strictly Hellenistic, rationalist political theoretician and hence a natural predecessor to the likes of Montesquieu, Hume, Smith and Durkheim, epitomizes this approach.

¹¹ Noah Gardiner, *Ibn Khaldūn versus the Occultists at Barqūq’s Court: The Critique of Lettrism in al-Muqaddimah* (Berlin: EB-Verlag, 2020); Matthew Melvin-Koushki, “In Defense of Geomancy: Šaraf al-Dīn Yazdī Rebuts Ibn Ḥaldūn’s Critique of the Occult Sciences,” in *Islamicate Occultism: New Perspectives*, ed. Matthew Melvin-Koushki and Noah Gardiner, special double issue of *Arabica* 64, nos. 3–4 (2017): 346–403.

¹² Alone among Islamicists who have written on the subject, Marco Schöller observes, rightly, that we must treat occultism as an important component of any concept of premodern Islamic humanism too, given its status as a primary means by which Muslim scholars retrieved, engaged and expanded upon the “wisdom of the ancients” (“Zum Begriff,” 316).

its attempted applications to Islamic societies reductive and problematic.¹³ In the case of the European Renaissance, however, certain core binaries seem to recur: it is anthropocentric yet evolutionary; it is perennialist yet progressivist; it is chauvinist yet concordist; it is elitist yet democratizing; its scientists are also its litterateurs; to be philological is to be political.¹⁴ Its operating principle, in short, is the *coincidentia oppositorum*, as established by Nicholas Cusanus (d. 1464), a good Pythagorean.¹⁵

One of the first early modern Muslim thinkers to develop just such an anthropocentric yet evolutionary, perennialist yet progressivist, chauvinist yet concordist, elitist yet democratizing, scientific yet literary, philological yet political, Hellenic yet Abrahamic and above all occultist doctrine was the Pythagorean Ibn Turka. His closest Christian cognates are the kabbalists Pico, Bruno and Dee, and he was just as strenuous an advocate of the *coincidentia oppositorum* (Ar. *majma' al-aḍḍād*) as Cusanus, his later Christian contemporary. Epitomizing this doctrine, the quranic dictum *He is the First and the Last, the Manifest and the Occult* (Q 57:3) runs throughout his oeuvre as watchword and motto.

Ibn Turka's radical – and radically Hellenic-Islamic – philosophy aside, the great benefit our Isfahani occultist provides to Western intellectual and cultural historians is the clarity and elegance of his exposition. Like Bruno in Italian and Latin, he was a brilliant stylist in Persian and Arabic. Also like Bruno, his gorgeous advocacy of a new cosmological imaginary¹⁶ earned him the ire of contemporary religious scholars and a series of inquisitions and punishments.¹⁷ Unlike Bruno, however, Ibn Turka did not perish on the pyre, and his unprecedentedly accessible

¹³ See, again, the comprehensive typology proposed in Schöller, “Zum Begriff.” In his classic study, George Makdisi makes humanism purely “classical” and equates it to *adab*, culturedness generally and literary excellence specifically; he elides occultism totally, save for a single mention of astrology (*The Rise of Humanism in Classical Islam and the Christian West* [Edinburgh: Edinburgh University Press, 1990], 287). Taking a broader yet more nuanced view, with tenth-century Iraqi Buyid culture as a case study, Kraemer emphasizes three traits, individualism, cosmopolitanism and secularism, and explicitly dismisses astrology and alchemy as irrelevant pseudosciences, fundamentally opposed to humanistic rationality – while noting the pervasiveness of these and other occult sciences in the Italian Renaissance (*Humanism in the Renaissance of Islam*, xxiii n. 34, 24, 135-36).

¹⁴ More generically, as Jill Kraye notes (“Preface,” in *The Cambridge Companion to Renaissance Humanism*, ed. Jill Kraye [Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1996], xv), Renaissance humanism was not “a narrowly philological enterprise,” but rather “a broad intellectual and cultural movement, which contributed to, or at any rate engaged with, disciplines such as biblical studies, political thought, art, science and all branches of philosophy.” Moreover, it is only in the early nineteenth century, in German, that “humanism” becomes a substantive, meaning “devotion to the literatures of ancient Greece and Rome, and the humane values that be derived from them” (Nicholas Mann, “The Origins of Humanism,” in *ibid.*, 1-2).

¹⁵ The definitive study here is David Albertson, *Mathematical Theologies: Nicholas of Cusa and the Legacy of Thierry of Chartres* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2014).

¹⁶ See Noah Gardiner, “Books on Occult Sciences,” in *Treasures of Knowledge: An Inventory of the Ottoman Palace Library (1502/3-1503/4)*, Vol. 1: *Essays*, ed. Gülrü Necipoğlu, Cemal Kafadar and Cornell H. Fleischer (Leiden: Brill, 2019), 557-87.

¹⁷ On Bruno, the classic study is of course Frances Yates's *Giordano Bruno and the Hermetic Tradition* (London: Routledge and Kegan Paul, 1964); on his kabbalistic thought see Karen Silvia de León-Jones, *Giordano Bruno and the Kabbalah: Prophets, Magicians and Rabbis* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1997).

Persian lettrist works (his Arabic ones are much more elitist) were best-sellers throughout the Persianate world, from India to Anatolia.¹⁸ Also unlike Bruno, his vernacularization and democratization of a new-old occult philosophy was for the benefit of a very different audience: many of his Persian treatises were expressly designed to transform Turko-Mongol warlords into philosopher-kings on the Solomonic-Platonic-Alexandrian model – a project in which he had some success. It is no accident that two of his four intended Timurid dynastic patrons, Iskandar Sultān (r. 1409-14) and Ulugh Beg (r. 1409-49), became famed as scientists, and the third, Bāysunghur b. Shāhrukh (d. 1433), became a preeminent patron of the book arts, and a calligrapher-litterateur in his own right. Most notably, Ulugh Beg, founder of the Samarkand Observatory and the most celebrated sultan-scientist in Islamic history, realized Ibn Turka's clarion call to mathematize astronomy along Pythagorean lines – a project that Copernicus, Kepler and Newton would later continue.¹⁹ This turn has been hailed by Islamicist historians of science as the basis for a new "mathematical humanism."²⁰

These features of Ibn Turka's project also make him both like and unlike Pico, father of Christian kabbalah but no scientist, and Dee, a failed Pythagorean imperialist and "patriotic occultist." Where Pico appropriated Hebrew kabbalah, inexpertly, to prove Jewish depravity,²¹ Ibn Turka was a native if innovative heir to the Islamic lettrist tradition, which had no sociopolitical need of such polemics. Where Dee tried and failed to convince Queen Elizabeth I (Spenser's Neoplatonic-kabbalist *Faerie Queene*) to colonize Turtle Island, aka North America, by means of astrological, alchemical, kabbalistic, genealogical, legal and cartographical arguments,²² Ibn Turka succeeded in helping transform three of his

¹⁸ On this theme see Melvin-Koushki, "How to Rule the World: Occult-Scientific Manuals of the Early Modern Persian Cosmopolis," *Journal of Persianate Studies* 11, no. 2 (2018): 140-54.

¹⁹ Melvin-Koushki, "The New Brethren."

²⁰ This term is proposed in İhsan Fazlıoğlu, "Between Reality and Mentality: Fifteenth Century Mathematics and Natural Philosophy Reconsidered," *Nazariyat* 1 (2014): 1-39.

²¹ Here the classic study is Chaim Wirszubski, *Pico della Mirandola's Encounter with Jewish Mysticism* (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1989).

²² See e.g. Frances Yates, *The Occult Philosophy in the Elizabethan Age* (London: Routledge, 1979), 89-90; Charlotte Artese, "King Arthur in America: Making Space in History for *The Faerie Queene* and John Dee's *Brytanici Imperii Limites*," *Journal of Medieval and Early Modern Studies* 33, no. 1 (2003): 125-41. On Dee's philosophical project more generally, see Håkan Håkansson, *Seeing the Word: John Dee and Renaissance Occultism* (Lund: Lund University Press, 2001). It should be noted that Christopher Marlowe's (d. 1593) depiction of Dee as Faust serves as a rough summary of contemporary lettrist-kabbalist practice (*The Tragical History of Doctor Faustus*, ed. Israel Gollancz [London: J. M. Dent, 1905], 4):

... Divinity, adieu!
 These metaphysics of magicians,
 And necromantic books are heavenly;
 Lines, circles, scenes, letters, and characters;
 Ay, these are those that Faustus most desires.
 O, what a world of profit and delight,
 Of power, of honour, of omnipotence,

patrons – with similarly expansionist ambitions – into Alexandrian philosopher-kings. In the historiography, however, the Welsh Christian Dee is a model of Faustus, mad occult scientist extraordinaire, while Ibn Turka, his Iranian Muslim peer and predecessor, has been erased from the historiography of science, of empire and of humanism altogether. He appears instead, when he is remembered at all, as a sufi – the designation he flatly rejects in the treatise translated below.²³

Lettrism vs. Sufism

Ibn Turka's occult-scientific challenge to sufism pivots on three Arabic concepts in particular: *taḥqīq*, or independent verification, and *insān kāmil*, the perfect human being, possessed of *walāya*, or sacral power. His use of the first goes to the core of what we might loosely call “scientific humanism”; his use of the latter two problematizes what we might loosely call “religious humanism.” I will address them in order.

The central term animating Ibn Turka's occult philosophy-science is *taḥqīq*, literally “making the real or true,” tantamount to experiential realization or experimentalist verification, and informing every discipline from natural philosophy to mystical ascent. Its root noun is *ḥaqq*, which in the definite form is a core divine name: the Real. Insofar as God is the only Necessary Existent (*wājib al-wujūd*) and the emanated universe merely contingently so, this became a contested term of art for a wide range of premodern Muslim thinkers and doers, from the most world-denying mystic to the most world-affirming technologist (sometimes the same person). In either respect, direct, personal experience became paramount. (Related terms in Arabic include *tajriba*, *dhawq*, *mushāhada*, *‘iyān* and *raṣād*, all likewise connoting personal inquiry, critical analysis and direct experience.²⁴) Ibn Turka, consciously combining these opposites, uses *taḥqīq* in both senses to assert lettrism as simultaneously the most transcendental and the most empirical of the human sciences – with a Pythagorean emphasis on the mathematical sciences – and hence proof of the superiority of the Moderns to the Ancients, on the one hand, and of lettrism to sufism, on the other.

Our occult philosopher is not the first to assert the epistemological and ontological supremacy of lettrism, however: here he is following his primary exemplar,

Is promis'd to the studious artizan!

On a similarly instructive English-Timurid political-theoretical parallel, see Azfar Moin, “Akbar's ‘Jesus’ and Marlowe's ‘Tamburlaine’: Strange Parallels of Early Modern Sacredness,” *Fragments* 3 (2013-2014): 1-21.

²³ The exception is Muḥammad-Taqī Dānishpazhūh's characterization of Ibn Turka as “the Spinoza of Iran,” likewise meant to spur researchers to recognize the revolutionary nature of his philosophical project (“Majmū‘a-yi rasā‘il-i Khujandī,” *Farhang-i Īrān-zamīn* 14 [1345-46 Sh./1966-67]: 312). As Spinoza was not a kabbalist, however, the comparison, while suggestive, is inexact, though both men were certainly panentheists.

²⁴ For references see Melvin-Koushki, “Is (Islamic) Occult Science Science?”

Ibn al-‘Arabī (d. 1240), the Andalusian Doctor Maximus (*al-shaykh al-akbar*) of Islamic “gnostic” or “mystical” philosophy, whose oeuvre is likewise permeated by the science, which serves as its key.²⁵ Yet that lettrism is not of a technological variety, but rather almost exclusively theoretical; it privileges metaphysics over physics and resists the systematization of either. Similarly, Ibn al-‘Arabī, following earlier, renowned sufi masters such as Ibn Barraġān (d. 1141),²⁶ privileges the path of *tahqīq* (or *tahaqquq*) over that of *taṣawwuf* (sufism) – a trope that would recur in subsequent sufi literature.²⁷ The same maneuver was made in applied lettrism during the same period, moreover, as epitomized by the oeuvre of the Ifriqiyān sufi mage Aḥmad al-Būnī (d. btw. 1225-31), in which the mathematical, talismanic manipulation of quranic divine names becomes paramount.²⁸ Later lettrist tradition would come to neatly bifurcate the science’s adepts into *ahl al-tahqīq* and *ahl al-khawāṣṣ* camps, or Ibn al-‘Arabian theoreticians and Būnian practitioners respectively.²⁹

But it is only with Ibn Turka – who first proposed this division, in order to resolve it – that lettrism is made to promote both the philosophization of warlords and the mathematization of astronomy: it is in his hands that the science becomes both a systematic metaphysics-physics and a basis for Islamic political theory.³⁰ For all that he draws, respectfully, on earlier sufi authorities, Ibn Turka’s claim to have transcended sufism with his new-old science is no mere rhetorical strategy, but his life’s project – hence the attempt to erase him from the Ibn al-‘Arabī school tradition by the great Timurid sufi and poet Jāmī (d. 1492) in particular, who had no truck with lettrism.³¹ That attempt did not succeed for several centuries. But it finally did in the modern period, aided and abetted by colonialist-Orientalist discourses, given the hostility of Islamicists and Muslim reformists alike to the occult sciences. As noted, Ibn Turka has come to figure in the literature as a minor “mystical” thinker at best, of no relevance to the history of humanism, the history of science or the history of empire, in extreme contrast to his Christian peers like

²⁵ See e.g. Denis Gril, “The Science of Letters,” in Ibn al-‘Arabi, *The Meccan Revelations*, ed. Michel Chodkiewicz, trans. Cyrille Chodkiewicz and Denis Gril, 2 vols. (New York: Pir Press, 2004), 2:105-219.

²⁶ The definitive study is Yousef Casewit, *The Mystics of al-Andalus: Ibn Barraġān and Islamic Thought in the Twelfth Century* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2017); on his self-distancing from sufism see *ibid.*, 2, 67ff.

²⁷ Willam C. Chittick, *The Sufi Path of Knowledge: Ibn al-‘Arabi’s Metaphysics of Imagination* (Albany: State University of New York Press, 1989), 4, 166, 389n11; *idem*, *The Self-Disclosure of God: Principles of Ibn al-‘Arabi’s Cosmology* (Albany: State University of New York Press, 1998), xxiv, 96-98; Alexander Knysh, *Sufism: A New History of Islamic Mysticism* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2017), *passim*.

²⁸ Noah Gardiner, “Esotericism in a Manuscript Culture: Aḥmad al-Būnī and His Readers through the Mamlūk Period” (Ph.D. diss., University of Michigan, 2014), 191.

²⁹ Melvin-Koushki, “The Quest,” 164, 275-80.

³⁰ On the latter move see Matthew Melvin-Koushki, “Imperial Talismanic Love: Ibn Turka’s *Debate of Feast and Fight* (1426) as Philosophical Romance and Lettrist Mirror for Timurid Princes,” *Der Islam* 96, no. 1 (2019): 42-86.

³¹ *Idem*, “The Quest,” ch. 8.

Pico, Bruno and Dee. But even the most general acquaintance with his oeuvre, his scholarly networks and his intellectual, cultural and political impact over many generations gives that anemic and polemical reception the lie.

The treatise here presented is a case in point. In *The Conclusion*, Ibn Turka offers his concisest definition of the objective of lettrism, as the ultimate form of philosophical *taḥqīq*: it is the “investigation into everything in the cosmos, both universals and particulars, and their categorization by means of this science.” And that investigation, he elsewhere emphasizes as a card-carrying Pythagorean, must be mathematical if it is to penetrate the structure of reality. It is difficult to imagine a definition more salient to the early modern (or indeed modern) history of Western science.

As for the history of empire: Ibn Turka’s embrace of the Ibn al-‘Arabian theory of the perfect man as microcosm was similarly empiricist and this-worldly, not merely otherworldly, and drove his not unsuccessful project to help create Timurid scientist-sultans. Where Ibn al-‘Arabī (who had no dealings with rulers) posited a complex hierarchy of sainthood presided over in every generation by a Pole (*quṭb*), or *axis mundi*, anonymous ruler of the world, Ibn Turka sought to make his Timurid patrons into perfect men by means of rigorous *paideia*. To this end, he promoted rather an equally hierarchical and ascending, seven-tiered curriculum. To achieve human perfection and microcosmhood, one must first master the traditional and religious sciences, proceed to dialectical theology, thence to Peripatetic philosophy, thence to Illuminationist philosophy, thence to sufism; only then may the aspirant proceed to lettrism, which constitutes the two highest tiers of human knowledge.³² Once one has mastered the occult intricacies of the science of letters, one is poised to achieve *walāya*, the sacral power of Imam ‘Alī and his line, historically tantamount to Plato and Pythagoras, disciples of Solomon. That is: *to be a lettrist is to be a second Pythagoras-cum-‘Alī*.

Marrying the opposites of religion and reason, in short, this curriculum is designed to create of uncultured men avatars of the divine names First and Last, Manifest and Occult, to make of warlords saint-philosopher-kings, whose right to universal rule may be scientifically proven by lettrist and astrological arguments.³³ Such arguments accordingly proliferated through at least the mid-seventeenth century in Persianate imperial chronicles, chancery documents and poetical panegy-

³² Idem, “The Occult Challenge to Messianism and Philosophy in Early Timurid Iran: Ibn Turka’s Lettrism as a New Metaphysics,” in *Unity in Diversity: Mysticism, Messianism and the Construction of Religious Authority in Islam*, ed. Orkhan Mir-Kasimov (Leiden: Brill, 2014), 247-76. Cf. the equally hierarchical and Pythagorean – but not lettrist – curriculum of the original Brethren of Purity (*Ikhwān al-Ṣafā*) of tenth-century Iraq, a primary inspiration to Ibn Turka and his circle – hence their self-presentation as the New Brethren of Purity. Cf. also Yaḥyā Kabīr, *Insān-shināsī (insān-i kāmil) dar maktab-i falsafī-yi ‘irfānī-yi Šā’in al-Dīn Ibn Turka* (Qom: Maṭbū‘āt-i Dīnī, 1384 Sh./2005), the only topical study to date of Ibn Turka’s theory of the perfect human – one that contains no mention of lettrism.

³³ Matthew Melvin-Koushki, “Early Modern Islamic Empire: New Forms of Religiopolitical Legitimacy,” in *The Wiley-Blackwell History of Islam*, ed. Armando Salvatore, Roberto Tottoli and Babak Rahimi (Hoboken, NJ: Wiley-Blackwell, 2018), 353-75.

rics, which increasingly asserted their various royal patrons to be the Manifest and Occult Pole of Poles (*quṭb al-aqṭāb*), Solomon and Alexander of the age. Ibn al-‘Arabī himself was adopted as the patron saint of the Ottoman Empire to this end – thanks not least to Ibn Turka’s laying of the necessary theoretical and practical groundwork in the interim.³⁴

As for the history of humanism: Ibn Turka is the first Muslim scholar to ontologically privilege textuality over orality, and to epistemologically equate writing and mathematics. Repurposing Ibn al-‘Arabī’s radical and controversial assertion of the superiority of sainthood (*walāya*) to prophethood (*nubuwwa*),³⁵ he defines *walāya* as rather the apotheosis of human knowledge over time and space, textually and mathematically, which alone is a reliable aperture onto the structure of the cosmos. Few redefinitions of this central Shi‘i-sufi term could be more radical. It is this new theory of writing that fittingly prefaced the boom in Persianate book and visual culture from the mid-fifteenth century onward, and informed the spread of riddle culture as a basic social and historiographical requirement; even certain imperial monuments, gardens and complexes came to be constructed as mathematical riddles – the Taj Mahal above all.³⁶ His exceptional dedication to the de-esotericization and democratization of occult science likewise presages the emergence of a new scholarly culture, current by the seventeenth century, in which books could and did serve as standalone teachers.³⁷

At the same time, Ibn Turka himself was not personally involved in philologically retrieving the wisdom of the ancients; his references to Greek sages presume the total Hellenic-Islamic synthesis long since achieved by the likes of Ibn Sīnā (Avicenna) and Suhrawardī. But his writings helped inspire the pronounced perennialist-antiquarian turn in Safavid philosophy, when pre-Socratic sages became all the rage, and new texts and fragments incorporated into mainstream scholarship by dedicated Illuminationists. Similarly, Ibn Turkian lettrism was adopted as a cosmological key by the imperial philosopher and chief jurisconsult Mīr Dāmād (d. 1631) himself, who likewise asserted its status as the supreme human science.³⁸

³⁴ See e.g. Cornell H. Fleischer, “A Mediterranean Apocalypse: Prophecies of Empire in the Fifteenth and Sixteenth Centuries,” in “Speaking the End Times: Prophecy and Messianism in Early-Modern Eurasia,” ed. Mayte Green-Mercado, special issue of *Journal of the Economic and Social History of the Orient* 61, nos. 1-2 (2018): 18-90; Michel Chodkiewicz, “The Esoteric Foundations of Political Legitimacy in Ibn ‘Arabī,” in *Muhyiddin Ibn ‘Arabī: A Commemorative Volume*, ed. Stephen Hirtenstein and Michael Tiernan (Shaftesbury: Element, 1993), 190-98; Adam Sabra, “The Cosmic State: Ibn al-‘Arabī’s Political Theology,” unpublished paper (2015); Aziz Al-Azmeh, *Muslim Kingship: Power and the Sacred in Muslim, Christian and Pagan Politics* (London: I.B. Tauris, 2001), 198-200.

³⁵ See e.g. Gerald T. Elmore, *Islamic Sainthood in the Fullness of Time: Ibn al-‘Arabī’s Book of the Fabulous Gryphon* (Leiden: Brill, 1999), 131-62.

³⁶ Melvin-Koushki, “The New Brethren”; Laura E. Parodi, “The Distilled Essence of the Timurid Spirit”: Some Observations on the Taj Mahal,” *East and West* 50 (2000): 535-42.

³⁷ Khaled El-Rouayheb, “The Rise of ‘Deep Reading’ in Early Modern Ottoman Scholarly Culture,” in *World Philology*, ed. Sheldon Pollock et al. (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 2015), 201-24; Melvin-Koushki, “How to Rule the World.”

³⁸ Matthew Melvin-Koushki, “World as (Arabic) Text: Mīr Dāmād and the Neopythagoreanization of Philosophy in Safavid Iran,” *Studia Islamica* 114, no. 3 (2019): 378-431.

On this and other bases, the Iran of Ibn Turka and the Italy of Pico are immediately comparable, and their invocations of man as microcosm perfectly parallel. The concern in some recent Islamicist scholarship that the *insān kāmil* category is too mystical to be properly defined as humanist is therefore unwarranted in our fifteenth-century context.³⁹ Granted, it is perhaps more *transhumanist* than humanist, albeit with emphasis on man as mind rather than man as machine – hence Ibn Turka’s equation of reading with immortality. Like a few but famed Christian humanists of the Renaissance, many early modern Muslim humanists stressed *theosis* (*ta’alluh*), self-divinization, as the goal of their program of education.⁴⁰ And yet this program had very concrete and measurable scientific, political and literary outcomes. For what could be more humanist than the insistence that we learn to read and write anew, through the prism of the ancients, the world as a mathematical text?

Conclusion: Reading as Sex as Islamic Humanism

Marriage and coupling –
that’s always what debaters seek.
I birth Him, He births me:
you see us forever marrying and birthing!
– Ibn al-‘Arabī⁴¹

Eros and language mesh at every point. Intercourse and discourse, copula and copulation, are sub-classes of the dominant fact of communication. ... Sex is a profoundly semantic act. ... The seminal and the semantic functions determine the genetic and social structure of human experience. Together they construe the grammar of being.
– George Steiner⁴²

³⁹ See e.g. Hinrich Biesterfeldt, “The Perfect Man – a Humanist?,” in *Humanism and Muslim Culture: Historical Heritage and Contemporary Challenges*, ed. Stefan Reichmuth, Jörn Rüsen and Aladdin Sarhan (Göttingen: V&R unipress, 2012), 101-13; for defenses of specifically sufi (not occultist) forms of humanism see Renate Wüsch, “Humanism and Mysticism,” in *ibid.*, 89-100; Stefan Reichmuth, “Humanism in Islam between Mysticism and Literature,” in *ibid.*, 115-26.

⁴⁰ Sajjad H. Rizvi, “Philosophy as a Way of Life in the World of Islam: Applying Hadot to the Study of Mullā Ṣadrā Shīrāzī (d. 1635),” *Bulletin of SOAS* 75, no. 1 (2012): 33-45. Cf. Jens Zimmermann, *Humanism and Religion: A Call for the Renewal of Western Culture* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2012), 39, 47 (he unfortunately relies on Goodman at p. 41).

⁴¹ Ibn al-‘Arabī, *al-Futūḥāt al-makkiyya*, 4 vols. (Beirut: Dār Sādir, n.d.), 3:371: *kulla-mā fī-hi nikāḥ^{un} wa-zdiwāj^{un} / huwa maqṣūd^{un} li-arbābi l-ḥijāji // fa-idhā antaja-nī untiju-hu / fa-tarā-nā fī nikāḥin wa-nitāji*. See Chittick, *Self-Disclosure*, 55. On a similar theme, Ibn al-‘Arabī describes his dream vision about a heavenly marriage contract as follows (*al-Futūḥāt al-makkiyya*, 2:416; trans. in Chittick, *Self-Disclosure*, 193): “I saw that that very Writ was my wife herself and identical to her. I laid and leaned upon her with my whole body.”

⁴² George Steiner, *After Babel: Aspects of Language and Translation*, 3rd ed. (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1998), 39-40; quoted in Elliot R. Wolfson, *Language, Eros, Being: Kabbalistic Hermeneutics and Poetic Imagination* (New York: Fordham University Press, 2005), 118. On kabbalah as scientific and literary humanism too, Steiner’s observations are penetrating and elegiac (*After Babel*, 60; see also 64-74):

In the annals of Western humanism, Ibn Turka is neither the first nor last writer to render reading a sexual act.⁴³ The same trope is used, for example, by the towering humanist poet Sa'dī of Shiraz (d. ca. 1292), whom Ibn Turka often quotes: to read a poem is to *deflower* it.⁴⁴ And many modernist writers have since deployed a similar theme, from Walt Whitman to Italo Calvino, as have language theorists from Claude Lévi-Strauss to Jacques Derrida.⁴⁵ While our Isfahani occult philosopher is consciously modernizing too, however, in the early modern humanist sense (indeed, he also styles reading *spiritual capitalism*), his is more than mere metaphor or poetical image, and not only deconstructive, but reconstructive too. To my knowledge, Ibn Turka is the first humanist writer to argue for reading-as-sex as a scientific, experimentalist, political statement of fact, advancing letter divination or letter magic as both a technological and a theosizing act. It is only by reading, he contends, that a true human being may be born, capable of copulating with the mathematical cosmos.

And he does mean copulation. It must be emphasized that sex and drunkenness came to serve as the central symbols of divine or cosmic union in the Islamic world generally and the early modern Persianate world specifically, in rather sharp contrast to contemporary Latin Christendom.⁴⁶ Indeed, Ibn al-ʿArabī, his primary source, infamously conducted a romance with Islamic civilization itself, embodied by a learned and gorgeous young Arabic-speaking Greek-Persian woman named Nizām (Harmony) he met in Mecca, and for whom he wrote an (in)famous volume of love poems. Sexual imagery recurs throughout the rest of his oeuvre too, though usually expressed in theoretical terms.⁴⁷ His adherent Ibn Turka – husband to several wives and father of ten children – was no stranger to either the physical or the mental act.⁴⁸ The latter's Pythagorean innovation here is rather in the concept of

[V]ia arcane images, Kabbalistic and emblematic constructs, through occult etymologies and bizarre decodings, the argument on Babel will feel its way – as did the partially astrological, Pythagorean hypotheses of celestial motion in Copernicus and Kepler – toward cardinal insights. More justly amazed than modern linguistics at the whole business of man's estrangement from the speech of his fellow man, the tradition of language mysticism and philosophic grammar reaches out to intuitions, to depths of inquiry, which are, I think, often lacking from current debate. Today we move on drier but shallower ground.

⁴³ On the sexual symbolism of kabbalah more generally, as approached through a Derridean interpretative framework, see Wolfson, *Language, Eros, Being*.

⁴⁴ Domenico Ingenito, *Beholding Beauty: Sa'di of Shiraz and the Aesthetics of Desire in Medieval Persian Poetry* (Leiden: Brill, 2020), 97.

⁴⁵ See e.g. Wolfson, *Language, Eros, Being*, passim; Marilyn Schneider, "Indistinct Boundaries: Calvino's Taste for Otherness," *Italian Quarterly* 30 (Winter-Spring 1989): 101-13.

⁴⁶ Shahab Ahmed, *What Is Islam? The Importance of Being Islamic* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2015), passim.

⁴⁷ Cyrus Ali Zargar, *Sufi Aesthetics: Beauty, Love, and the Human Form in the Writings of Ibn 'Arabi and 'Iraqi* (Columbia: University of South Carolina Press, 2011); Sa'diyya Shaikh, *Sufi Narratives of Intimacy: Ibn 'Arabi, Gender, and Sexuality* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 2012).

⁴⁸ Melvin-Koushki, "The Quest," 60.

mathematical-textual sex, whether physically, poetically, philosophically or politically expressed.

For Ibn Turka and his intellectual predecessors and heirs insist on civilization itself as the natural product of *cosmic love*, mathematically defined by his fellow Pythagorean Isaac Newton (d. 1727) as gravity. It is through this force alone that all complexity coalesces, that the cosmos matures. As synonym to this English term, celebrated by Francis Bacon (d. 1626) in his perennialist meditation on Cupid,⁴⁹ Ibn Turka constantly cites instead the classic sufi concept *al-nikāḥ al-jārī fī jamīʿ al-dharārī*: the marriage act pervading all atoms.⁵⁰ Yet his meaning here is not “mystical,” but humanist, in the most pragmatic, cosmopolitan, state-building sense of that term. To achieve civilization is to harness the *coincidentia oppositorum* on all possible fronts: inner court and outer, caliphate and imamate, fighting and feasting, bureaucracy and military, nomad and settled, Arab and Persian, Persian and Turk, Greek and Chinese, East and West, ancient and modern, white and black, male and female, Sunni and Shiʿi, religion and reason, tradition and science, mind and matter, heaven and earth, time and eternity, love and justice.⁵¹

As the example of Ibn Turka and his *Conclusion* elegantly shows, to discount Islamic occultism generally and lettrism specifically as but Oriental, otherworldly and unscientific “mysticism” is to render this major element of early modern Islamic humanism *unreadable*, and alien to Western intellectual and cultural history – an operation that would seem to be antithetical to any humanist philology.⁵² To be sure, the Latin Christian humanism of the Renaissance, in its parochial and chauvinist zeal to return to a pure, purely “European” textual source, was also often anti-Arabist; it is the genesis of our modern fiction of Islam as essentially un-Western.⁵³ Similarly, our reflexive etic conflation of Islam with religion and

⁴⁹ “Cupid; or, the Atom,” *Wisdom of the Ancients*, in *The Works of Francis Bacon*, ed. James Spedding et al., 14 vols. (London: Longman, 1861-79), 6:729-30.

⁵⁰ See n. 29 above.

⁵¹ Melvin-Koushki, “Imperial Talismanic Love.” Despite the similar investment of Ibn Turka’s German contemporary and cognate Nicholas Cusanus – a litigator who ended his life as a papal vicar in Rome – in political affairs, the latter does not seem to have developed a similar political theory; see Albertson, *Mathematical Theologies*. The closest late-antique cognate to Ibn Turka’s version of the theory is that of the Syrian Neopythagorean Iamblichus (d. 330), whose mathematizing doctrine likewise had direct political effect, inspiring Julian the Apostate (r. 361-63) to become an Alexandrian philosopher-king; see e.g. Gregory Shaw, “Eros and Arithmos: Pythagorean Theurgy in Iamblichus and Plotinus,” *Ancient Philosophy* 19 (1999): 121-43. For a wide-ranging account of premodern and modern European (and American) theories of love, from cosmic to magical, see Wouter J. Hanegraaff and Jeffrey J. Kripal, eds., *Hidden Intercourse: Eros and Sexuality in the History of Western Esotericism* (Leiden: Brill, 2008).

⁵² Occultism aside, it must now be granted that early modern Islamic humanism too (to adopt Jill Kraye’s abovementioned definition of European Renaissance humanism) was no “narrowly philosophical enterprise,” but rather “a broad intellectual and cultural movement” that contributed to and engaged with “disciplines such as [quranic] studies, political thought, art, science and all branches of philosophy” – including occult philosophy (“Preface,” xv).

⁵³ Dag Nikolaus Hasse, *Success and Suppression: Arabic Sciences and Philosophy in the Renaissance* (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 2016); Melvin-Koushki, “*Tahqīq* vs. *Taqlīd*.”

occultism with mysticism works to make such sharp emic distinctions between sufism and lettrism historiographically illegible. But if Pico himself could claim kabbalah as the ultimate human science, and yet be acclaimed father of humanism,⁵⁴ why not extend the same acclaim to Ibn Turka, who did the same, seven decades before, to greater scientific, philosophical, political and literary effect? Should we continue to avert our philological gaze from the early modern humanists of Islam, simply because they too conceived of philology in cosmic – indeed cosmically sexual – terms?⁵⁵

*The Conclusion; or, Sufism versus Lettrism*⁵⁶

*In th NM of GD ALLMRCFUL EVRMRCFUL*⁵⁷

Boundless praise be to God, Who at the beginning as Creator apportioned out singly each atom of every existent – *It began from Him* – and at the end as Sovereign will make tally of these same atoms – *and to Him it returns* –

Unbelief and belief chase after Him
chanting *To Him alone without partner*;

and choicest blessings be strewn upon the pure earth of the Chosen One, [Muḥammad], in the absence of whose message not a single atom of eternity would have been conveyed from the womb of nothingness into the circuit of being.

This treatise constitutes a felicitating dispatch from the realm of truth treating of the respective objectives of the science of sufism (‘ilm-i taṣavvuf) and the science of letters (‘ilm-i ḥurūf), albeit in abbreviated and summary form. In keeping with the dictates of this accession I have found it necessary to treat of the purpose of these two noble sciences, the firstfruits of the era and moist buds in the garden of this age, in such a manner that everyone will be capable of grasping it. The treatise has accordingly been written such that on the pages of manifestation and communication its contents will be comprehensible to all.

Needless to say, ancient Greek philosophers did not identify as European – yet even certain medieval Muslim thinkers were made European by Renaissance scholars out of parochial ignorance.

⁵⁴ Wirszubski, *Pico della Mirandola's Encounter*. As Makdisi notes (*The Rise of Humanism*, 307), Pico's opening and definitive quotation in the *Oration* from “Abdala the Saracen” may refer to the great Muslim humanist Ibn Qutayba (d. 889).

⁵⁵ Hence my proposed term *cosmic philology* (Melvin-Koushki, “Is (Islamic) Occult Science Science?,” 317).

⁵⁶ This translation is based on my edition of the treatise from Tehran, MS Majlis 10196, ff. 157b-59b (the earliest and most complete collection of the author's works, featuring his autograph); MS Majlis 10004, pp. 153-62; see Melvin-Koushki, “The Quest,” 490-97.

⁵⁷ This standard quranic benediction is written with unjoined letters (most normally joined in Arabic script), following the format of the *muqatta'āt*, or the cryptic unjoined letters opening 29 suras, and a primary inspiration to and focus of lettrist analysis.

One must address you according to your measure:
if I raise my discourse but slightly it'll be hard for you to hear.⁵⁸

The work comprises a prologue, two sections and an epilogue.

Prologue

Know that the human being is superior to all other species of living beings by virtue of his knowledge and insight, and through his rational faculty he crowns creation; all are subject to his command, as is indicated by His saying, *He has subjected to you all that is in the heavens and in the earth* (Q 45:13). Now there are many types of knowledge, but the choicest among these is wisdom (*hikmat*),⁵⁹ of which He said, *Whoso is given wisdom has been given much good* (Q 2:269). For it is through this type of knowledge that the reality of everything is made manifest to a person; a man deprived of the aid of its rules and left to his own devices is incapable of perceiving things as they truly are. It is through inquiry into wisdom's incontrovertible principles that one is enabled to recognize one's self as the principal stock-in-trade of the divine realities and features, for it is from the soul that one derives knowledge of Origin and Return, the message that all prophets have been charged with bringing and the most prized jewel in the treasurehoard of these chosen ones.

For years my every thought has been the question:
Why am I oblivious to my condition of my own heart?
Where have I come from and why?
Where am I going and how will this happen?

Know that this science was in former times extrapolated from the utterances of the prophets (upon whom be peace) by the learned of every age. The latter then communicated it to the world, giving people to understand with the radiance of their inspiration-bound words the path to this science, much in the way that historians do with their chronicles.

Every fragrance you think comes from musk and clove
emanates rather from the province of that hyacinth tress!⁶⁰

⁵⁸ Awḥadī, qasida: *agar ḥaqāyiq-i ma 'nā bi gūsh-i jān shinuvī*.

⁵⁹ This term is also often used to denote philosophy as such, as Ibn Turka does below.

⁶⁰ 'Irāqī, quatrain: *har būy ki az mushk u qaranful shinavī*.

Section One: On the Discipline of Sufism and Its Goals

If the foregoing is clear to you, know that this science of wisdom was more prevalent in the time of the previous prophets, and especially in the time of Solomon, on whose teaching and the teaching of his companions great thinkers such as Anaxagoras, Pythagoras, Socrates and others have drawn – truly, their noble philosophies have beautified the lineaments of the age, as anyone with a modicum of insight may see from their magnificent writings.

When the Tatar roe grazes among the blossoms
the breeze bears the scent of musk to market.⁶¹

But by the time that the blessed advent of the Arab prophet Muḥammad drew near and the dawn of his being broke from behind the horizon of felicity, the starry ranks of these sciences of wisdom and philosophy had departed the heaven of manifestness for the veil of occultation, with but a small fraction of them being communicated and discussed. The reemergence of the mainstream version of philosophy familiar to schoolmen, which derives from Aristotle, the First Teacher, and was reformulated by Ibn Sīnā, its modern master, received its impetus from the new revelation – that point at which the sun of wisdom gave forth the rays of prophecy's Seal who, long obscured behind the west of the Arabs, now rose from the east of the Quraysh, illuminating the world and time with the lights of guidance. Basking in this nourishing Seallight the gardens of wisdom-philosophy again grew fresh and verdant and under the warm radiance of its subtleties the fields of knowledge and gnosis sprouted luxuriantly anew, each field blooming with innumerable flowers and each branch on its all-encompassing tree groaning with every kind of fruit. In short, the garden of knowledge and learning saw the growth of the most rarefied sciences and choicest modes of wisdom and the flowerbed of realities and meaning bloomed with the subtleties and glories of gnosis.

Each instant this garden produces fruits
each fresher than the last!

Out of an elevated sense of purpose a group of the leading scholars of this community held it requisite to adhere to the example of the Prophet, and by dint of their emphasis on his holy custom beautified their inner and outer selves through tireless self-examination and effort; in so doing these exemplary individuals became hosts to wisdom and from the blessed breath of each proceeded diverse occult and wondrous sciences (*gharāyib-i 'ulūm*) – this fact is obvious to those who are savvy traders in the market of acumen and the shop of knowledge, being well acquainted with the worth of the capital possessed by the merchants of knowledge in each era. The historical cycles having thus drawn ever

⁶¹ Nizāmī, *Khusraw u Shīrīn*, pt. 64.

closer to their centerpoint of sacral power (*valāyat*), the edifice constructed upon the foundational truths of these sciences became ever grander and its soaring turrets reached new heights. These developments are clear to the intelligent whose feet are firmly planted at the station of perspicacity and whose insight prompts them to the examination of the works of these great thinkers as not incompatible with the approach of organized and prescriptive religion.

You know still what I'm saying:
if it happens to you pass beyond to the intellect's realm.⁶²

These words having embroidered your mind's robe of honor, then, the science of sufism may thus be seen as constituting a mode of wisdom that is formulated in terms of Muḥammad's Custom and the prescriptions of his revelation, and has its place among the permitted sciences and required practices. Mainstream philosophy constitutes a [complementary] science that is formulated in terms of inductive proofs and rational demonstrations, and likewise has its place among the permitted sciences and required practices. Consider the difference in their methods and compare the point of departure and end result of each.

The Chosen One is in this cosmos where one imagines Intellect to be,
a Sun in that sphere where one strains to see Suhā!⁶³

The objective of the science of sufism is likewise clear to the perspicacious: its program of education and training aims to elevate a person beyond the level of mere animal physicality and accidental being by means of the proven methods and practices contained in the prophetic teachings so as to attain to the level of human perfection and eternal life, thereby escaping entrapment in the darkness of the flesh where one is cut off from the fount of the water of life.

That spring from which the Green Man drank the water of life⁶⁴
is in your own home, but you've blocked it off!

Section Two: On the Discipline of Lettrism and Its Goals

Know that the prophets sent by God (the blessings and peace of God be upon them all) – the nightingales of this marvelously storied garden – communicated

⁶² Awḥadī, tarjī': *dar kharābāt-i 'āshiqān kūyī-st.*

⁶³ I.e., the faint star Alcor in Ursa Major; finding it in the night sky was regarded by the Arabs as a test of sight. The verse is by Sanā'ī.

⁶⁴ In Islamic reports, the Green Man (Khiḍr) was Alexander the Great's cook, who stumbled upon a spring of the Water of Life while on campaign with him in Central Asia, thereby becoming one of the Four Immortals.

their burden in the language of their people and in the idiom peculiar to each, as indicated by the divine saying: *We have sent no messenger except in the tongue of his people* (Q 14:4). The divinely inspired message that they convey makes known to those outcast and exiled in the desert of estrangement the dictates of divine law and guides them to the straight path to the Abode of Peace by means of conventional expressions, metaphors and customary tropes; at the same time it explicates truths and instances of wisdom to the initiates of the court of nearness and the companions of the harem of oneness and intimacy, with every letter thereof giving them to understand a myriad matrices and principles of knowledge and gnosis and pouring out before them priceless treasures and precious jewels, this likewise in the form of conventional allusions and lettersigns.

This, however, is not to be understood as the typical conventionality of usage which is arbitrary and artificial and used by the majority to express themselves, but is rather a conventionality or situationality that corresponds to that which is fundamental and real, a suitable mode of expression for the heavenly Speech and capable of communicating its message to the elite of the elite from among the initiates of the seclusion chamber of the elect.

So many subtle meanings are hid in the line on his lip
of which you are unaware, litterateur – but I know them.⁶⁵

(I have treated of this and related points with the appropriate depth in my *Book of Investigations* [*Kitāb al-Mafāḥiṣ*].⁶⁶) Know moreover that the above statement holds true for all other prophets and perfected individuals – how much more so then for the perfect Arabic Quran with which the Seal, Muḥammad (God’s blessings and peace be upon him and upon his House), was sent to all peoples! For its every letter, including both its unjoined differentiating and contiguous recitative letters, discloses a wealth of glorious instances of wisdom and makes known the fundamentals of important sciences.⁶⁷ Yet it is the denizens of the realm of skill, conversant as they are in the language of the new generation, that discover this fact and demonstrate the superiority of the perfect wisdom of the Muḥammadan revelation to the wisdom brought by previous prophets and sages.

Rose, what are you next to his pretty face?
He is musk and you – full of thorns!
Narcissus, what are you next to his intoxicated eye?
He is charmingly tipsy and you – drooping drunk!⁶⁸

⁶⁵ Ḥāfiẓ, ghazal: *yārī andar kas namī-bīnīm yārān-rā chi shud*.

⁶⁶ This is Ibn Turka’s magnum opus, and the first summa of Islamic Neopythagoreanism; see Melvin-Koushki, “The Quest,” ch. 7.

⁶⁷ The first category, *muqatta‘a ‘a-yi furqānī*, refers to the mysterious isolated letters that open 29 quranic suras, constituting half of the Arabic alphabet.

⁶⁸ Ḥāfiẓ, ghazal: *ay bād-i nasīm yār dārī*.

If the thrust of this premise may be considered graven on the tablets of intelligence, it will be seen that the science of letters is a science that encompasses all that can be known, whether particular or universal, by means of analysis of the state of the revealed heavenly forms and the nature of the shapes of those substances, the priceless gift prophets and messengers bear from the majestic Presence to His servants.

To clarify this definition we may divide the sciences of wisdom into two categories. The first comprises those that deal solely with universals as objects of knowledge, the approach of mainstream philosophy; any method that relies on inductive reasoning belongs to this type. The second comprises those that do not deal only with universals but encompass both universals and particulars; any method that relies on proofs derived from the revealed heavenly forms belongs to this type, and takes as its proof-text the verse *There is nothing fresh nor withered but it is in a manifest Book* (Q 6:59). This latter category may be understood as having as its point of departure Solomon's ability to understand the speech of the birds. It is a science governed by rules and predicated on the first principles of the sensible forms and the self-evident aspects of the visual and auditory elements of that which has been revealed to the prophets; the set of problems with which it deals includes the associations that obtain between intuitively-known matters and [the propositions of the] primordial sciences.

[Given such principles and concerns], this science cannot be affected or altered by the constant revolution of historical cycles, nor can the cold, dustchoked winds of happenstance tatter to the summits of its exaltation. None may attain to its sanctuary save with a stride on the scale of eternity and a yearning for Oneness – those who haunt the alley of discursive thought and those who keep to the seclusion chamber of passion-induced fantasies remain far from this path.

Dive! – you might just find a pearl.
Now divers require several skills:
Trusting a friend with the rope,
taking your life into your hands,
holding your breath,
turning head over heels.

As for the objective of the science of letters, it is obvious to insightful members of the circle of perspicacity and inhabitants of the alley of native intelligence that every substance that is worthy to be carried by the caravans of the prophets (God's peace be upon them all) from the abode of eternity and the keep of holiness is strapped onto their loads by archangels delegated from among the ranks of the heavenly host and sent down to the workshop of temporal circumstance till that in the midst of the market bustle these *men faithful to their covenant with God* (Q 33:23) open their loads in accordance with His command *Deliver what has been sent down to you* (Q 5:67). These men, having reached adult perfection and acquired virility so as to serve as models of emulation, then become buyers accord-

ing to the amount of currency of innate capacity each has in the purse of his high purpose and intent, and through their taking possession of that precious substance depart from the state of trackless exile and attain to the court of proximity to the majestic Presence, so becoming worthy of guidance. They then ascend through the degrees of faith, submission and virtue⁶⁹ according to the ability of each to bear and fathom the treasures therein, so becoming envied and admired by the angelic host.

By what measure could one hope to pen a single line in description of those substances? What human faculty of perception possesses the ability to carry away a single leaf from the garden of that perfection into the forest of perception? For it is only by saying *I do not recount*⁷⁰ that a fragrance from the garden of those substances and a breeze bearing their praises may be wafted to the ear of comprehension for those wandering heedless in the valley of confusion.

Who are we that we should be silent from praising You?
But we pant for You to speak and praise Yourself!⁷¹

This, then, is what one may say in general terms as to the gorgeous qualities of those veiled virgins dwelling the household of holiness and the harem of eternity. To speak in more specific terms, the perfect and mature wisdom propounded in the eloquent speech of Muḥammad, the Arab Seal of prophecy, was expressed through the medium of verbal allusions and conventional expressions of long standing, its definitive proofs and clear arguments effortlessly productive of certitude and virtue. It is clear to the inhabitants of the alley of attentiveness and perspicacity that any science which can clearly formulate knowledge of all things, both universals and particulars, and whose principles and questions clarify the nature of every level of divine and engendered existence, from that of engendered beings up to that of the [fixed] entities, such that the ornament of proof shines forth brilliantly from the folds of its expositions (as may be demonstrated to those seekers whose degree of perception and purpose is but slightly less than that of the Heirs of the Seal's legacy and who are acquainted with his devoted servants) – such a science surpasses all others in value.

My heart said, I long for mystical knowledge!
Teach me if you're able.
I replied, *A*. It said, Yes, and? I said, That's it:
if anyone's home a single letter will suffice.

⁶⁹ I.e., the trinity given in the Hadith of Gabriel, here listed out of order: *islām, imān, iḥsān*.

⁷⁰ *Lā uḥṣī*, a reference to the famous hadith (recorded in e.g. Muslim, *Ṣaḥīḥ*, *Kitāb al-Ṣalāt*, no. 1118) in which Muḥammad says in a night prayer: "I do not recount Your praise – You are as You have praised yourself!"

⁷¹ Awḥadī, ghazal: *gar bi-ngarī dar āyina rūzī šafā-yi khwīsh*.

Now this [allusive] mode of communication is unique to the perfect reality-expounding speech of the Seal: for know that the veiled virgins of the prophetic house and harem can never leave their concealment nor can they be seen by questing travelers save by means of analogy and simile.

A thousand observers, yet no one's seen your face!
A hundred nightingales await you, and you still in the bud!⁷²

Recently a number of locks securing the veils that shroud the quranic grandeur have been opened and an exposition of its eloquent texture has been given through the good offices of the Moon-splitting writings of Sayyid [Ḥusayn Akhlāfī],⁷³ such that the one to whom it is granted that the black radiance of those scrawls give to the light of the scouts of his seeing and scrutiny the power to comprehend a color of this type may thereby join the ranks of those who understand the language of the new generation and partake of the brides of the marriage chamber of the letters, the eternal Speech. In this process one attains to the type of maturity unique to human beings, as distinct from the merely physical maturity of animals, which latter is all the common run of people know.

To understand this point, consider physical maturity, which is marked by the ability to experience sexual arousal: when confronted by a member of the opposite sex the physical apparatus, that is, the member, becomes engorged and sensitized so as to be capable of experiencing [orgasmic] pleasure. By virtue of this process another animal of the same species may be engendered, possessed of merely accidental life that cannot persist. Likewise, true human maturity is marked by the ability to experience a similar kind of arousal in which when confronted by a member of the *human* opposite sex – human here meaning the ability to speak and to reason using the letters that make up the eternal Words – an individual becomes capable of experiencing pleasure, by which process a true human being is born, possessed of eternal life. As an adept would say:

If you listen you will live forever.
If not, my breath will return to me.

Furthermore, just as [the onset of] physical maturity is accompanied by certain signs, such as a strong urge and sex drive with regard to one's mate and thinking constantly of the pleasure to be had with her, so too is [the onset of] true human maturity signaled by the urge to be conjoined with one's human spouse and thinking constantly of the pleasure to be had with her.

⁷² Ḥāfīz, ghazal: *rū-yi tū kas na-dīd u hizār-at raqīb hast*.

⁷³ I.e., the Tabrizi Kurdish occultist who was responsible for training the most prominent lettrists of Ibn Turka's generation, including Ibn Turka himself, who became his protégé in Cairo; see Melvin Koushki, "The New Brethren."

Now my purpose in citing this example here is twofold: First, to demonstrate that an immature person is incapable of comprehending the science of letters; a prepubescent youth must first acquire the human virtue of manliness, called chivalry by the sufis, so he may discover the pleasure to be had with a spouse and not remain barred from entering the showroom of beauties where the brides of the marriage chamber of eternity – that is, the unjoined differentiating letters – are paraded.

If you be a man, plant your foot firmly; if not,
abstainers aren't admired on this path.

Second, the objective of the science of letters having been thusly defined, it is abundantly clear from the foregoing that in this polluted bazaar which operates with the currency of physical existence it is nevertheless possible to anyone whose capital of resolve is equal to the purchase to carry away from his transaction eternal life.

The dignity of love is great, so show some resolve, Hafez:
lovers don't let the irresolute into their ranks!⁷⁴

Epilogue

I close this treatise with mention of several reports from the righteous forebears that support the points made above. For the Imams from the House of the Prophet and the caretakers of the household of prophecy (God's good pleasure be upon them all), who constitute the pillars of the edifice of wisdom and gnosis, have left a number of traces upon the pages of time. Each of these is considered by the intelligent to be a sign proving the validity of this noble science [of letters] and indicating the rightness of its abovementioned objective, to wit, investigation into everything in the cosmos, both universals and particulars, and their categorization by means of this science. However, to restate the foregoing in terms that beginners can understand it is necessary to reference several instances in this connection.

An instance is cited by al-Tha'ālibī⁷⁵ who reports that when the holy verse *HM* 'SQ (Q 42:1-2) was revealed the Prophet appeared to be overcome by exhaustion. A group of Companions who were with him at the time asked 'Alī b. Abī Ṭālib, governor of the realm of sacral power and intimate in the harem of mysteries, what untoward event had caused this exhaustion in the Prophet's blessed constitution. After looking into the matter 'Alī informed them that it was on account of the verse which had just been revealed, "for it indicates that the Prophet's noble community

⁷⁴ Hāfiz, ghazal: *sharāb-i bī-ghashsh u sāqī-yi khūsh dū dām-i rah-and*.

⁷⁵ See n. 71 below.

will after the expiration of the period of guidance treat his exalted family most improperly.”

A second instance is given in the chronicles of the House of the Prophet to the effect that during the reign of al-Ma'mūn, the crown jewel in the necklace of the 'Abbasid line, due to the advancement of the charger of his fortune and the superiority of the stallion of his resolve the caliph was honored to receive audience with Imam 'Alī b. Mūsā al-Rizā, that fresh bud in the garden of divine good pleasure and firstfruit of the orchard of election; through the boon of his elixir-like attention the caliph escaped from the desert of exile and rejection to the city of nearness and acceptance and pledged his devotion to and belief in him. Thus did a fragrance emanating from the garden of perfections that was the Imam beguile the nostrils of the caliph's soul through the grace of his company till that the intoxicating force of his longing moved him to action and the reins of self-restraint and control (as dictated by the maxim *Kingship is childless*) were wrested from his capable hands, this in a manner described by Ḥāfiz:

From your draught I've become drunk – enjoy it;
from what cask have you taken what's in your jar?⁷⁶

– indeed, this became his anthem. In short, he requested from the Imam that an official letter of compact be prepared by truthful pens to provide for his security, and with the throne of the caliphate and kingship irradiated with the Imam's magnificent presence he would stand at attention to serve him. The Imam, acting in accordance with the divine saying, *Obey God and obey the Messenger and those in authority among you* (Q 4:59), acceded to the caliph's request, and the compact was duly drawn up in a spirit of great affection. However, in the course of a subsequent meeting the Imam said [to the caliph], “The compact has been written, but there is no doubt that this caliphate [you propose for me] will come to nothing.” Al-Ma'mūn asked him how he knew this, and he replied, “It is counterindicated in the *Jafr* and *Jāmi*’.”⁷⁷ They also say that at the head of the letter of compact this line was written: “I have written this in accordance with your desire, but the *Jafr* and *Jāmi*’ indicate the contrary.”⁷⁸

A third instance concerns Abū l- 'Āliya, one of the foremost Quran commentators,⁷⁹

⁷⁶ Ḥāfiz, ghazal: *Ṣabā tū nakhat-i ān zulf-i mushk-bū dārī.*

⁷⁷ Lit., the Calfskin and the Comprehensive, referring to divinatory texts associated with members of the Prophet's family. See Hossein Modarressi, *Tradition and Survival: A Bibliographical Survey of Early Shī'ite Literature*, Vol. 1 (Oxford: Oneworld Press, 2003), 4-12, 17-20.

⁷⁸ On this narrative see e.g. Muḥammad Bāqir Kh"ānsārī, *Rawḍāt al-jannāt fī aḥwāl al- 'ulamā' wal-sādāt*, ed. Asad Allāh Ismā'īliyān, 8 vols. (Tehran: Maktabat Ismā'īliyān, 1392 Sh./1972), 3:237. In later Persianate usage the two terms are conflated to denote a Comprehensive Prognosticon, much prized as political technology at the Ottoman and other courts (Fleischer, “A Mediterranean Apocalypse,” *passim*).

⁷⁹ Abū l- 'Āliya Rufay' al-Riyāhī (d. ca. 709), a Successor from Basra, was a traditionist credited as an early quranic exegete. His strong position on the explicability of the *muqatta'āt* is confirmed even in Ibn Kathīr's (d. 1373) conservative *Tafsīr* as follows (ed. Muḥammad Ḥusayn Shams al-Dīn, 9 vols.,

who conveyed from reliable transmitters the following statement: “The unjoined letters (*muqattaʿāt*) are letters of light which have been revealed at the beginning of certain quranic suras. A group of people asked the scholars the meaning of these letters; they answered that they contain knowledge of many things, and the rise and fall of [political] groups in particular.”

Now my purpose in citing these instances was to give intelligent people to understand that although this science may not be much discussed by hidebound scholars of the madrasa and the sufi lodge, the great figures of previous generations, who sought to divest people of their musty observances and habits, have always praised it and held it in high regard. In short, these episodes have been recorded here solely for the benefit of those shortsighted individuals who inhabit the alley of caprice – for those a quest on the highway of affliction already experience myriad ineffable pleasures from each delectable point touched on in this treatise as are beyond all compare.

If it is indeed wine from your cup that has made me drunk
then wine dupes drunks like a mirage.

Peace be upon those who follow guidance.

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[Beirut: Dār al-Kutub al-ʿIlmiyya, 1998], 1:68):

[¹⁴ was reported that Abū l-ʿĀliya said] on the Most High’s statement *ALM*: “These three letters belong to the 29 letters common to all languages. There is not a letter among them that does not begin one of His names. There is not a letter among them that is not one of His blessings and tests. Nor is there a letter among them that does not indicate the period [of survival] of peoples and their appointed term.”

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